

Study finds highways weaken social ties across U.S. cities.

New research published on March 4, 2025, shows that highways may be doing more than moving cars — they are also weakening social connections in major U.S. cities.

Researchers compared social connections with the location of highways to see how major roads affect human connections. In total, the analysis covered nearly one million people and more than 2.5 million social ties.

In Detroit, removing one highway segment could lead to 62% more crossings between nearby neighborhoods. The effect is strongest at short distances, peaking below 5 km and fading beyond 10-20 km.

In simple terms, this shows how much a highway can reduce everyday social connections between people living close to each other.

The research shows which roads are most likely to cut communities in half, helping cities see where a highway makes meeting, walking, cycling or staying connected much harder.

Where in your city does a road feel like a wall?

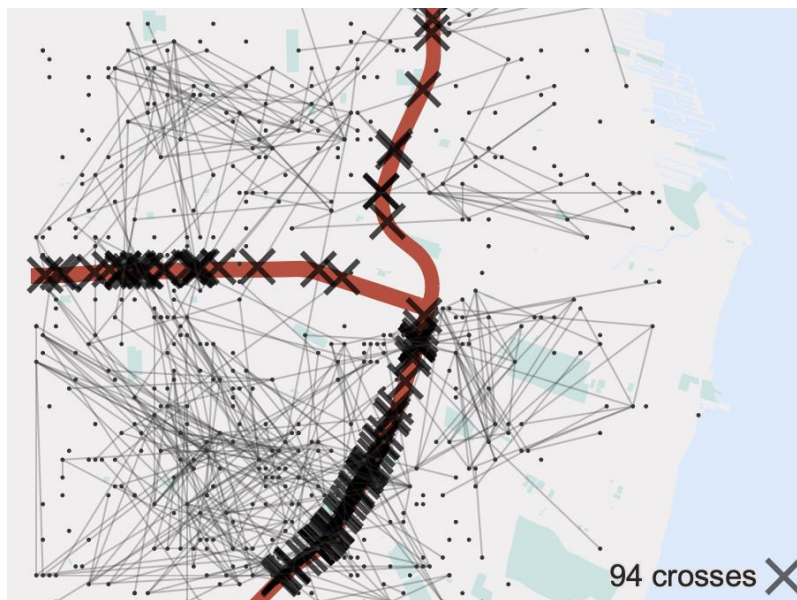


Figure 1: A highway divides nearby homes and social connections in Detroit. Source: Urban highways are barriers to social ties, PNAS (2025).